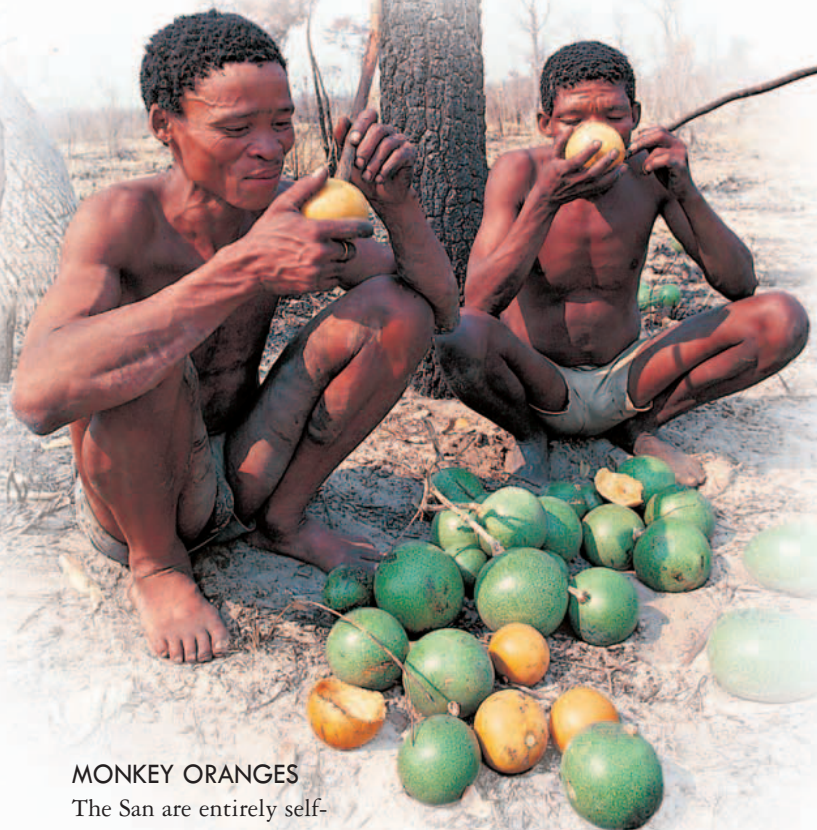




SAN

HUNTER-GATHERERS OF THE KALAHARI

OFTEN REFERRED TO AS “BUSHMEN,” the many different groups now known as San are the original inhabitants of the Kalahari Desert in South Africa, Botswana, and Namibia. Their lifestyle resembles that of the



MONKEY ORANGES

The San are entirely self-sufficient and are skilled at getting every possible use from the little that is available in the bush. The fruit of the monkey orange tree is good for quenching thirst but also has a number of other uses. The fruit can be used as dye or soap, the bark as medicine, and the leaves to heal wounds.



A FLEXIBLE LIFESTYLE

A San community consists of a few extended families who are all related to each other. Everyone builds their homes close together inside a walled compound. The doors to each home face toward the central area where people meet, cook, and socialize. When water and food have become scarce, the group simply leaves the homes to fall apart naturally and moves to a new site where they build another camp.

The San way of life

Survival in the desert requires a number of different skills. Men make weapons and hunt for animals, while women fashion skin bags and use these to gather fruit and nuts. In San society everything is shared and everyone is treated equally. When an animal is killed the meat does not belong to the person who killed it but is shared with the entire group. Although there is no formal leadership, skilled and experienced individuals are highly respected.



ROOTS AND TUBERS

Roots and tubers provide moisture as well as food to the San. Women are expert at finding and digging these up, and are also knowledgeable about their medicinal properties and uses.

SAN CAVE ART

The oldest San cave paintings are thought to be 27,000 years old. The animals represented in the cave paintings may record the experiences of San spiritual leaders. These leaders, or shamans, would hold a trance dance to heal someone or ensure good hunting. The paintings show what the shaman may have seen while in a trance.

